

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Western herbal medicine, helonias has been valued as a key remedy for conditions affecting the uterus and ovaries. It is thought to have a “normalizing” effect on the female reproductive system. It is thought to regulate the release of hormones by the ovaries and encourage a regular menstrual cycle. It has also been used to treat conditions such as endometriosis, ovarian cysts, and menopausal problems. As it is now an endangered species, other herbs (notably black cohosh) are routinely used in its place.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Chamaemelum nobile syn. *Anthemis nobilis* (Asteraceae) Roman Chamomile

Description Aromatic perennial growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has feathery leaves and daisy-like flower heads.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to western Europe, Roman chamomile is now cultivated across Europe, and also in other temperate regions. The flowers are harvested as they open in summer.

Parts Used Flowers, essential oil.

Constituents Roman chamomile contains up to 1.75% essential oil (including tiglic and angelic acid esters, chamazulene and other sesquiterpene lactones), flavonoids, coumarins, and phenolic acids.

History & Folklore

Though called Roman chamomile, this herb was not cultivated in Rome until the 16th century, probably arriving there from Britain.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A remedy for the digestive system, Roman chamomile is often used interchangeably with German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77). However, an infusion of Roman chamomile has a more pronounced bitter action than its German namesake. It is an excellent treatment for nausea, vomiting, indigestion, and loss of appetite. It is also sedative, antispasmodic, and mildly analgesic, and will relieve colic, cramps, and other cramping pains. By stimulating digestive secretions and relaxing the muscles of the gut, it helps normalize digestive function. Roman chamomile may also be taken for headaches and migraine, even by children. Its marked anti-inflammatory and antiallergenic properties make it helpful when applied to irritated skin.

Cautions Do not use the essential oil internally except under professional supervision. The essential oil is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.



Dried flower heads

Chamaenerion angustifolia syn. *Epilobium angustifolium* (Onagraceae)

Rosebay Willowherb

Description Perennial growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has an erect stem, narrow leaves, and long spikes of pink-purple flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation This herb is found in Europe and western Asia, and grows in clearings, along roads, and in open areas. It is picked when in flower in late summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Rosebay willowherb contains flavones and tannins.

History & Folklore In Siberia, an alcoholic drink has been made from this herb and the fly agaric mushroom (*Amanita muscaria*).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Demulcent and astringent, rosebay willowherb treats diarrhea, mucous colitis, and irritable bowel syndrome. It has also been made into an ointment to soothe skin problems in children. Rosebay willowherb is used to treat prostate problems.

Cheiranthus cheiri (Brassicaceae) Wallflower

Description Evergreen perennial growing to 18 in (45 cm). Has lance-shaped leaves and yellow-orange flowers appearing in spring.



The Greek physician Dioscorides (1st century CE) used wallflower roots to treat gout.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southern Europe, wallflower is now found throughout the continent. It grows on cliffs and old walls, and is a common garden plant.

Parts Used Leaves, flowers.

Constituents The herb contains cheiranthin and other cardioactive glycosides.

History & Folklore In 1735, the Irish herbalist K'Eogh described wallflower thus: “It provokes urination and menstruation and expels a stillborn child, and the afterbirth if a decoction of the dried flowers or a little seed is drunk in wine.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Although wallflower was formerly used as a diuretic, there was no understanding of its powerful effect on the heart. In small doses it is cardiotonic, supporting a failing heart in a manner similar to foxglove (*Digitalis purpurea*, p. 202). In more than small doses it is toxic, and is therefore rarely used in herbal medicine.

⚠ Cautions Use only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Chelidonium majus (Papaveraceae)

Greater Celandine

Description Thin-stemmed perennial herb growing to a height of 3 ft (90 cm). Has indented yellow-green leaflets and 4-petaled flowers, which appear in clusters in late spring.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, western Asia, and North Africa, greater celandine flourishes close to human habitation, preferring open areas, the banks of roadsides, and damp places. The aerial parts of the herb are collected in late spring or early summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts, latex.

Constituents Greater celandine contains isoquinoline alkaloids, including allocryptopine, berberine, chelidonine and sparteine. Several of these alkaloids are analgesic. Chelidonine is antispasmodic and also lowers blood pressure. Sparteine, by contrast, raises it.

History & Folklore In folk medicine, greater celandine has often been viewed as a cure-all. It has also been used for thousands of years to treat and clear the eyesight, especially cataracts. According to Pliny and Dioscorides (both writing in the 1st century CE), swallows used the latex that flows from cuts in the stems or leaves as a means to sharpen their eyesight. In 1598, Gerard recommended the herb for eye disorders “for it clenseth and consumeth awaie slimie things that cleave about the ball of the eie.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Greater celandine acts as a mild sedative, relaxing the muscles of the bronchial tubes, intestines, and other organs.